backwardness, and non-viable nature of state finances) need to be revisited.

SOCIO-ECONOMIC AND CASTE CENSUS

The identification of the real beneficiaries is of paramount importance, for the success of any targeted approach. In line with this approach the *Dr. N. C. Saxena Committee* was constituted to advise on the 'methodology for a BPL census in rural areas'. Since June 2011, for the first time, a ***Soci-Economic and Caste Census (SECC)*** is being conducted – through a comprehensive door-to-door enumeration in both rural and urban India, authentic information is being made available on the socio-economic condition and educational status of various castes and sections through the SECC.

This exercise will help better target government schemes to the right beneficiaries and ensure that all eligible beneficiaries are covered, while all ineligible beneficiaries are excluded. Households identified as highly deprived will have the highest inclusion priority under government welfare schemes. Use of the *Aadhar* number in various beneficiary-oriented social–sector programmes will also check duplications.

The *SECC 2011* is being conducted simultaneously for rural and urban areas by the respective states, with technical and financial support from the GoI. Enumeration is to be done with the help of about 6 lakh enumerators, who are accompanied by an equal number of technically qualified and computer literate Data Entry Operators (DEO) selected by the country's premier IT majors. The Ministry of Rural Development in association with the Ministry of Housing and Urban Poverty Alleviation, Office of the Registrar General of India (RGI) and the states have shouldered the responsibility of training the enumerators, supervisors, verifiers, and state officials engaged in the census operation. The SECC process ensured transparency and people's participation.

Before finalising the outcomes, the household data, except caste data, will be placed in the public domain for scrutiny and go through a two-stage